

HERBY GREEN BULGUR SALAD

INGREDIENTS

2 cups Bulgur Wheat dry (I used Turkish Bulgur)
3 cups boiling water
1 tsp. Salt or more to taste

1/4 cup olive oil
1 cup cucumber diced
1 Zucchini, diced
1 cup green onion chopped
3/4 tsp. Cumin powder
3 tbsp chopped chives
1 lemon juiced
2 tbps. pomegranate molasses
2 tablespoons Jalapeño Pepper
1 stalk celery chopped
1/2 cup crumbled feta cheese

For the Herb Dressing

1/2 cup whole milk Greek yogurt
1 cup fresh parsley
1 cup mixed soft leafy herbs, dill, mint, tarragon and/or cilantro
2 tablespoons chopped chives
2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice, plus 1/2 teaspoon zest
1 tablespoon extra-virgin olive oil
2 teaspoons capers
1 small garlic clove
1/4 teaspoon sea salt
Freshly ground black pepper

METHOD

Step 1

In a bowl, soak the bulgur with the boiling water for 20-30 minutes, mixing occasionally until they are soft and tender. Bulgur should not be chewy. Set aside to cool completely.

Step 2

Meanwhile dice and chop all your ingredients.

Step 3

In the bowl of a food processor combine all your ingredients for the dressing and blend until smooth.

Step 4

Add in the bulgur and mix to coat well with dressing.

Step 5

In a bowl, add in all the salad ingredients with the bulgur, lemon juice and cumin. Taste to see if you prefer to add more salt.

Step 6

Drizzle with pomegranate molasses and serve right away or store in the fridge and serve cold.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

LEMON BLUEBERRY CHEESECAKE BARS

INGREDIENTS

For the crust:

2 cups all-purpose flour

½ cup granulated sugar

½ teaspoon salt

1 cup (2 sticks) butter - chilled and cut into small cubes

For the filling

240gms cream cheese - softened

2 cups granulated sugar

¼ cup flour

¾ cups fresh-squeezed lemon juice

⅓ cup powdered sugar - plus more for topping

1 cup blueberries

6 large eggs

1 teaspoon vanilla

METHOD

STEP 1: Preheat oven to 350 degrees and line a 9x13 inch pan with foil or parchment with plenty of overhang around the edges to lift the bars out of the pan before cutting.

STEP 2: Prepare the crust by combining flour, sugar, salt, and butter cubes in a food processor or blender. Cover and pulse until fine crumbs form. (You can also do this with a pastry cutter, fork, or with your fingers in a large bowl.)

STEP 3: Press crust into prepared pan and bake for 10 minutes while you prepare the filling.

STEP 4: Prepare the filling by combining cream cheese and sugar in a large bowl. Cream together until smooth. Mix in flour, powdered sugar, lemon juice, eggs, and vanilla until completely incorporated. Now stir in the blueberries.

Pour filling over crust and return to oven for 30 minutes.

STEP 5: Allow to cool for about 20 minutes, then cover and transfer chill in the fridge 4 hours or overnight. Lift the foil edges to remove the bars from the pan, slice into squares, sprinkle with additional powdered sugar, and serve.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

ROASTED TENDERSTEM WITH LIME SOUR CREAM SAUCE

INGREDIENTS

500g tenderstem broccoli or regular
broccoli cut into florets
2 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
1/4 tsp each salt and pepper
1 garlic clove , finely minced

Sour Cream Sauce

1/2 cup sour cream
1/4 cup Greek Yoghurt
1.5 tsp honey
1 -2 tbsp lime juice
Zest of lime
1/2 garlic clove, crushed smooth
1/4 tsp each salt and pepper
2 Tbsp finely chopped chives

METHOD

STEP 1:

Preheat oven to 220°C/425°F (200°C fan).

Step 2:

Sauce: Mix Sour Cream Sauce ingredients until combined. It should be loose enough so it can be drizzled, but not too runny. Set aside 15 minutes.

Step 3:

Toss broccoli : Pile broccoli on tray, drizzle with oil, sprinkle with salt, pepper and garlic.

Step 4:

Roast for 12 - 15 minutes until the broccoli floret ends are dark brown and crunchy (the best part!), and the broccoli stem is just tender. (But if you want it really soft, lower temp to 180C/350F and cook 20 min).

Step 5:

Plate up: Transfer to serving plate, allow to cool until warm. Drizzle over tahini sauce, sprinkle with almonds or pine nuts and serve! Excellent served warm OR at room temp.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Carpaccio di zucchini

Ingredients:

500g green zucchini
500g yellow zucchini
5 tablespoons (100ml) extra virgin olive oil
Juice of 1 small lemon
2 teaspoons grated lemon rind
225g baby rocket
100g shaved parmesan

Directions:

Step 1

Trim the ends of the zucchini and slice diagonally into wafer-thin rounds. Place in a bowl.

Step 2

Combine the oil, lemon juice and rind, and season with salt and pepper. Pour mixture over zucchini and leave for 5 minutes. Pile the rocket onto serving plates, then top with the zucchini and finish with the parmesan.

Step 3

Serve as a first course or as an accompaniment to simply grilled meat and fish.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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GAMBERONI ALLA GRIGLIA

INGREDIENTS

1 kg of prawns
100 ml of extra virgin olive oil
4 clove of garlic, finely pasted
1 tablespoon chopped parsley
2 tsp chili powder
2 tsp paprika
60ml white wine
Salt and Pepper To Taste

METHOD

STEP 1

Start by putting the oil in a bowl, then add the white wine, a pinch of salt and pepper. Emulsify everything with a whisk. Then add the pasgted garlic, paprika, chili powder and the chopped parsley.

Step 2: Arrange the prawns in a baking dish and sprinkle them with the emulsion you have prepared. Let it cook for about 30-40 minutes, or just the time when the embers will be ready to start grilling them.

Step 3: Place the prawns on the hot grill, then, after about 3 minutes, turn them on the other side too, to cook them evenly.

Step 4: The cooking times of grilled prawns can vary depending on the intensity of the heat and the height at which the grill is placed. Cooking is usually very short and never lasts more than 7-8 minutes.

Step 5: As soon as the prawns are evenly browned, you can remove them from the grill and place them in the dishes or in a tray.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

TURKISH BULGUR SALAD

INGREDIENTS

2 cups Bulgur Wheat dry (I used Turkish Bulgur)
3 cups boiling water
1/4 cup tomato paste
2 tablespoons roasted red pepper paste
1 tsp. Salt or more to taste

1/4 cup olive oil I used Turkish Olive Oil
1 cup cucumber diced
1 red bell pepper diced
3/4 cup green onion chopped
1/3 cup fresh parsley chopped
3/4 tsp. Cumin powder or 7 spice
1 lemon juiced
2 tbps. pomegranate molasses
1/3 cup purple onion optional
2 tablespoons Jalapeño Pepper optional if you like spicy

METHOD

Step 1

In a bowl, soak the bulgur with the boiling water for 20-30 minutes, mixing occasionally until they are soft and tender. Bulgur should not be chewy.

Step 2

Meanwhile dice and chop all your ingredients.

Step 3

In a frying pan bring the olive oil, salt, tomato and pepper paste to simmer and keep cooking on low for about 5-7 minutes, stirring occasionally to form a creamy tomato paste base. Turn off the heat.

Step 4

Add in the bulgur and mix to coat well with the tomato paste. Allow the bulgur to cool down for about 10 minutes.

Step 5

In a bowl, add in all the salad ingredients with the bulgur, pomegranate molasses, lemon juice and cumin. Taste to see if you prefer to add more salt.

Step 6

Serve right away or cool in the fridge to serve cold.

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SPANAKOPTA

INGREDIENTS

1kg. fresh spinach, washed, dried, trimmed, and coarsely chopped
3 Tbs. extra-virgin olive oil
1 bunch scallions (about 3 oz. or 10 small), white and light-green parts only, trimmed and finely chopped
2 cups crumbled feta cheese (10 oz.)
1/2 cup finely grated Greek kefalotyri cheese or Parmigiano-Reggiano
2 large eggs, lightly beaten
1/2 cup finely chopped fresh dill
1/3 cup finely chopped fresh flat-leaf parsley
1/4 tsp. freshly grated nutmeg
Kosher or fine sea salt

For the assembly:

1/3 cup extra-virgin olive oil for brushing; more as needed
Eighteen 9x14-inch sheets frozen phyllo dough, thawed and at room temperature
2 tsp. milk

METHOD

TIP:

Phyllo dries out very fast and becomes brittle when exposed to the air. Check out our test kitchen tips for working with it. Position a rack in the center of the oven and heat the oven to 375°F.

Make the filling: Heat a 10-inch straight-sided saute pan over medium-high heat. Add a few large handfuls of the spinach and cook, tossing gently with tongs. As the spinach starts to wilt, add the rest a few handfuls at a time. Cook until all the spinach is wilted and bright green, about 4 minutes. With a slotted spoon, transfer the spinach to a colander set in a sink. Let cool slightly and squeeze with your hands to extract as much of the remaining liquid as you can.

Wipe the pan dry with a paper towel. Heat the oil in the pan over medium heat. Add the scallions and cook until soft and fragrant, about 4 minutes. Stir in the spinach, turn off the heat, and let cool for 5 minutes. Then stir in the cheeses, eggs, dill, parsley, nutmeg, and 1/2 tsp. salt and mix thoroughly.

Assemble the pie: With a pastry brush, lightly coat the bottom and sides of a 9x13x2-inch baking pan with some of the oil. Working quickly, lightly oil one side of a phyllo sheet and lay it in the pan oiled side up and off center so that it partially covers the bottom and reaches halfway up one long side of the pan (the edge on the bottom of the pan will be about 1 inch from the side). Lightly oil the top of another phyllo sheet and lay it oiled side up and off center so it reaches halfway up the other long side of the pan. (If your pan has sloped sides, the sheets may be slightly longer than the bottom of the pan; if so, let the excess go up one short side of the pan and then alternate with subsequent sheets.) Repeat this pattern with 4 more phyllo sheets.

Next, lightly oil the tops of 3 phyllo sheets and layer them oiled side up and centered in the pan. Spread the filling evenly over the last layer.

Repeat the oiling and layering of the remaining 9 phyllo sheets over the filling in the same way you layered the previous 9. With the oiled bristles of the pastry brush, push the edges of the phyllo down around the sides of the pan to enclose the filling completely.

With a sharp knife, score the top phyllo layer into 24 rectangles, being careful not to cut all the way through to the filling. Using the same pastry brush, brush the milk along all the score marks (this will keep the phyllo from flaking up along the edges of the squares). Bake the spanakopita until the top crust is golden brown, 35 to 45 minutes. Let cool until just warm. Cut out the rectangles carefully along the score marks and serve.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

SIRLOIN STEAK WITH CRYING TIGER SAUCE

FOR THE CRYING TIGER SAUCE

2 tbsp. Tamarind sauce
2 tbsp. Fish sauce
½ tbsp. Palm sugar
1 tbsp. Chili flake
1 tbsp. Grounded roasted rice
½ tbsp. Chopped shallot
½ tbsp. Chopped spring onion
½ tbsp. chopped coriander

FOR THE SIRLOIN STEAK

300g sirloin steak
½ tbsp. oyster sauce
1 tbsp. seasoning sauce / Maggi Sauce
1 tbsp. cooking oil

For the Crying Tiger Sauce:

Step 1: Combine tamarind sauce, fish sauce and palm sugar and mix well until sugar dissolves.

Add chili flakes, grounded roasted rice and all herbs. Taste and adjust if required.

For the Steak:

Step 1: Use the fork to pierce the beef all over then add seasoning sauce and oyster sauce. Give it a good rub for around 5 mins before adding the oil and again rub well.

Step 2: Leave the beef marinade for 15-20 min. Then cook as your preferred method like grilling on charcoal, BBQ or pan grill.

Step 3: Rest the steak before slicing and serve with dipping sauce.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

ROASTED BALSAMIC TOMATO & THYME GALETTE

For the cherry tomato filling

500gms cherry tomatoes
2 tablespoons olive oil
2 tablespoons balsamic vinegar
7-8 cloves garlic adjust to taste
1 tablespoon fresh chopped thyme
¼ teaspoon salt

For the Galette Pastry

1 and ½ cups all purpose flour
½ teaspoon salt
½ cup unsalted butter
5-6 tablespoons ice cold water

For the galette dough

Step 1: Mix together the flour and salt in a large mixing bowl. Using a pastry cutter or your fingers, cut in the cubes of butter until they are crumbly and pea-sized.

Step 2: Mix in the ice-cold water one tablespoon at a time, stirring with a wooden spoon until a cohesive ball of dough forms. The dough will still be slightly crumbly, that's okay. Wrap tightly in plastic wrap and let rest in the fridge for 30 minutes.

Preheat the oven to 220C.

For the cherry tomato filling:

Step 1: Meanwhile, prep the filling. Roughly chop the garlic. Heat the olive oil over medium heat in a large skillet. Add the garlic, cherry tomatoes, balsamic vinegar, thyme, and salt. Saute just until the cherry tomatoes burst, about 8-10 minutes, stirring frequently. Set aside.

To assemble the galette

Step 1: On a lightly floured surface, roll out the pastry dough into a 12-inch circle. Place on a parchment paper lined sheet pan or on a preheated pizza stone.

Step 2: Pour the cherry tomato filling into the center of the galette, leaving about 2 inches of a border. Fold the border in over just the edges of the cherry tomatoes

Step 3: Bake for 25-30 minutes at 220C on the middle oven rack, until the galette is golden brown. Remove the galette from the oven and allow to cool for 10 to 15 minutes before cutting.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Zuppa di Cozze

Ingredients:

3 tbs. olive oil
1 medium onion, chopped
2 stalks of celery, chopped
3-4 cloves of garlic, minced
Salt & Pepper to taste
1/2 cup dry white wine
1 cup Water
1 (14 oz.) Can Chopped Tomatoes
1,5 kg mussels, scrubbed with beards removed
1/4 cup chopped fresh parsley

Directions:

Heat the oil in a large saucepan and saute the onion, celery and garlic until translucent.
Add the tomatoes, salt and pepper and cook 5-10 minutes or until the sauce begins to thicken.
Add the wine and cook an additional 10 minutes, adding as much water as needed if the sauce becomes too thick.
Add the cleaned, drained mussels, cover, and cook until the shells open, which should be about 5 additional minutes.
Add the parsley just before serving.
You can serve this dish on grilled garlic bread, spooning the juices over the bread in a shallow bowl, or serve with a good crusty bread on the side.

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COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

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WHIPPED FETA WITH HERBS AND CRISPY PITA CHIPS

For the whipped feta

240gms good quality feta, drained and rinsed

¾ cup Greek yogurt

1 lemon zest

2 tablespoon extra virgin olive oil, more as needed

1 teaspoon Aleppo pepper, or red pepper flakes (to your taste)

2 tablespoons chopped fresh mint

2 tablespoons chopped fresh parsley

For the seed topping:

1 teaspoon toasted sesame seeds

¼ teaspoon chilli flakes

¼ teaspoon lemon zest

2 teaspoon extra virgin olive oil

For the pita chips:

4 pita

2 tsp sumac spice

2 tsp zaatar

1/2 tsp salt

3tsbp olive oil

Instructions

For the whipped feta

Step 1: In the bowl of a large food processor fitted with a blade, combine the feta, Greek yogurt and lemon zest. Blend, and while the processor is running, drizzle olive oil through the top opening, until the feta is whipped to a smooth mixture.

Step 2: Transfer the whipped feta to a serving plate. With the back of your spoon, smooth the top of the feta, making an indentation in the middle (or a "well"). Pour a bit of olive oil all over the feta, then top with your sesame spice topping.

For the spice topping

Step 1: Warm a frying pan over a medium heat, then add your sesame seeds, stir continuously, being careful not to let any burn, until the sesame seeds are fragrant and toasted.

Step 2: Transfer the sesame seeds to a bowl and add the other ingredients, stir to combine and set aside, and use to top your whipped feta.

For the pita chips

Step 1: Warm your pita for 20 seconds in the microwave to help them loosen up, then slice in half through the pita. Now cut the pita into 12 or so chips (as you would a pizza)

Step 2: Add the olive oil, spices and salt to a bowl, stir to combine, then add the pita chips and gently toss them to coat with the seasoning, being careful not to break them.

Step 3: Place the pita chips in a single layer and bake in a hot oven, 220C on the middle wrack, turning once or twice, until golden and crunchy. Keep an eye on them as they can burn easily.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

STRAWBERRY GELATO

STRAWBERRY ICE

INGREDIENTS

400 g fresh strawberries

150 g granulated sugar

250 ml whole milk

250 ml heavy cream

METHOD

1. To make strawberry gelato at home, start by washing and drying the strawberries thoroughly. Remove the stalk and, if present, any damaged or unripe parts.
2. Cut the strawberry into pieces and put them in a blender or in the container of an immersion blender and blend the strawberries well, until you have a smooth puree. Check that no large chunks remain.
3. Pour the strawberry puree into a bowl and add the sugar.
4. Add the heavy cream and finally the whole milk. Mix thoroughly with a spoon until the sugar is completely dissolved.
5. At this step, pour the mixture into the basket of the ice cream maker, close and start it. After about 40 minutes (the time may vary depending on the model of the machine) your strawberry gelato will be ready! Sweet, fresh and creamy. You just have to taste it!

THE
COOKERY

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ASPARAGUS & LEMON FETTUCINE

INGREDIENTS

⅔ cup extra-virgin olive oil
1 large bunch asparagus, trimmed, thinly sliced
on a deep diagonal
4 garlic cloves, smashed
Zest of 1 lemon
½ tsp. crushed red pepper flakes
8 large basil leaves
1 lemon juiced
60gms. Parmesan, finely grated (about 1 cup),
plus more for serving

METHOD

Step 1

Cook pasta in a large pot of boiling salted water, stirring occasionally, until al dente. Drain pasta, reserving 1½ cups pasta cooking liquid.

Step 2

Meanwhile, heat oil in a large Dutch oven or other heavy pot over medium-high until shimmering. Add asparagus, season with salt, and cook, stirring often, until just beginning to take on color, about 1 minute.

Step 3

Add garlic, lemon zest, and red pepper flakes and cook, stirring, until fragrant, about 30 seconds. Add the cream and reduce by half.

Step 4

Add lemon juice to half a cup of reserved pasta water, add this along with the pasta and basil to pot with asparagus mixture and return to medium-high heat. Now add 60gms Parmesan and more reserved pasta cooking liquid as needed.

Step 5

Cook, tossing vigorously, but gently and adding more pasta cooking liquid if needed, until sauce is creamy and emulsified and pasta is coated, about 1 minute. Taste and season with more salt if needed. Remove and discard garlic or paste and add back for a bold punchy flavour.

Step 6

Divide pasta among bowls, placing a lemon strip in each, and top with more Parmesan.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Tandoori Chicken Skewers

Ingredients:

6 Tbsp vegetable oil
2 teaspoon ground coriander
2 teaspoon ground cumin
2 teaspoon ground turmeric
2 teaspoon Kashmiri chili powder
2 Tbsp garam masala
2 Tbsp sweet (not hot) paprika
2 cup plain yogurt (can sub buttermilk)
4 Tbsp lemon juice
8 minced garlic cloves
4 Tbsp minced fresh ginger
2 teaspoon salt
10 chicken breasts cut into chunks (deboned thighs work very well)

Method:

1. Preheat the oven to 200C, fan on. Soak skewers in water
2. Heat the oil in a small pan over medium heat, then cook the coriander, cumin, turmeric, cayenne, garam masala and paprika, stirring often, until fragrant (approximately 2-3 minutes). Let cool.
3. Mix the spice mixture into the yogurt, add lemon juice, garlic, salt, ginger and stir till combined.
4. Coat the chicken pieces with the marinade, and chill for at least an hour (preferably 6 hours but no longer)
5. Thread the chicken pieces onto the skewers
6. Place the skewers on a roasting tray and roast in the hot oven till cooked through and slightly charred. Don't overcrowd the roasting tray and turn once during cooking.

Hint: These are fantastic on the braai, brush the grid with some oil before placing the skewers on and cooking till charred and ready.

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PANTZAROSALATA

INGREDIENTS

400g strained yogurt
2 medium raw or pre-cooked beets
2-4 sheets minced garlic (depending on
how strong you want it)
Salt to taste
1/2 cup finely chopped walnuts
1 tbsp chopped dill
2-3 tbsp. vinegar
5-6 tbsp. olive oil

METHOD

STEP 1:

Using gloves grate the beet on the fine side of a grater.

STEP 2:

In a bowl add your yoghurt, finely minced or grated garlic, salt, vinegar, finely chopped dill and olive oil. Whisk to combine.

STEP 3:

Add the finely grated beet to the dressing and stir will to combine. Taste and adjust seasoning.

STEP 4:

Top with the roasted walnut pieces and some extra dill, serve as a dip or as a salad besides roasted meats.

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Chicken & Roasted Red Pepper Soup

Ingredients

12 red peppers
10 chicken thighs
2 tbsp olive oil
1 onion, peeled and chopped
2 garlic cloves, peeled and crushed
1 ½ litres chicken stock
Handful fresh basil leaves, torn
Handful fresh mint leaves, torn
2 tsp fresh oregano
Salt and black pepper
Extra virgin olive oil to serve

Method

1. Preheat oven to 200° C. and roast the peppers for 25 minutes, then leave to cool. Scrape out the seeds, peel, and slice thinly
2. At the same time cook the chicken thighs. Season them with salt and pepper and roast alongside the peppers for 20 minutes, or until cooked through. Cool. Discard skin and bones and shred meat
3. Heat oil in a large saucepan, add onion and saute until golden. Add strips of peppers and the garlic and cook further for 2 minutes
4. Add the stock to the peppers along with the chicken and herbs. Adjust seasoning and simmer for 5-10 minutes

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ARANCINI WITH ANCHOVY & MOZARELLA

INGREDIENTS

For the rice

1 cup long-grain rice
1 small onion
1 stick celery finely chopped
1 small carrot finely chopped
4 tbs. butter
3 cups chicken broth
5 tbs. grated Parmigiano

For the filling:

80 gms finely diced Mozzarella
10 - 12 anchovy fillets
30gms parsley, chopped
1 egg

To coat the arancini

3 eggs
breadcrumbs
nutmeg
olive oil
salt
pepper
Flour

METHOD

Step 1: In a heavy based pot saute the onion, carrot and celery in the butter until soft and translucent. Then add the rice and fry it until it is sizzling. Then add the hot broth slowly, stirring frequently. The rice should be done in about 20 min. When the rice is ready, mix in half the parmesan, and then spread the rice out in a flat baking tray to cool.

Step 2: Mix the chopped mozzarella and finely chopped anchovies, the rest of the parmesan, the chopped parsley, 1 egg, nutmeg, salt and pepper (If the mixture is a little wet add some more parmesan). With slightly damp hands, take a handful of rice in one hand, and a pinch of stuffing with the other. Push the stuffing into the middle of the rice. Squeeze the rice all around the stuffing and mould it into an egg shape.

Step 3: When you have used up all the mix, flour the croquettes, dip into beaten eggs, and then roll again in breadcrumbs. Fry the suppli' in very hot oil, once golden and cooked through place on paper towel to drain and serve immediately

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

GRILLED NECTARINE & MOZARELLA SALAD

INGREDIENTS

15g unsalted butter
2 tbsp caster sugar
50g whole pecans
3 ripe nectarines, stoned and cut into eighths lengthways
4 tbsp extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for brushing
2 tbsp balsamic vinegar
1 tsp honey
2 x 100g balls of fresh mozzarella
70g rocket
bunch of basil leaves, roughly torn
pinch of chilli flakes

METHOD

STEP 1

Heat the butter and sugar in a small frying pan over a medium heat until the butter has melted. Add the pecans and stir to coat in the buttery sugar. Continue to cook for about 5 mins, stirring until the pecans are crisp and caramelised. Tip out onto a sheet of baking parchment and leave to cool. Once cooled, roughly chop and set aside.

STEP 2

Heat a griddle pan over a high heat and generously brush the nectarine slices with some olive oil. Griddle for 1-2 mins on each side until charred and caramelised. Remove to a serving platter and set aside.

STEP 3

Whisk the 4 tbsp olive oil, vinegar and honey together with some seasoning to make a dressing.

STEP 4

Scatter the rocket and basil across the base of your serving plate, then nestle the charred nectarine before tearing the balls of mozzarella and dotting across the salad. Drizzle over the dressing, scatter with the pecans and sprinkle with a pinch of chilli flakes to serve.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

Asparagus & Pancetta Risotto

INGREDIENTS

8 cups vegetable stock
2tbsp olive oil
1 medium onion, diced
1 stick of celery, finely chopped
1 carrot, finely chopped
200gms, diced pancetta
2 cups arborio rice
1 cup white wine
1 tablespoon flat leaf parsley, chopped
4 tablespoons cold butter
200gms asparagus
150gms grated pecorino
Salt and pepper

To Make the Risotto

1. Heat the oil in a large saucepan. Now add the diced pancetta. Fry until golden and crispy.
2. Remove half the pancetta and reserve for later. Add onion, carrot and celery and season with salt and pepper
4. Add the rice and stir to coat with pork fat and oil; cook until rice is slightly translucent.
5. The rice should be hot and sizzling, you should stir carefully to ensure it does not stick.
6. Add wine to the hot rice, the liquid should hiss and be quickly absorbed. Stir gently until almost all the liquid has cooked off. Add hot stock mixture, a ladleful at a time, stirring in the liquid each time.
7. Remember at this stage you are trying to coax the starches out the rice by gently and continuously stirring. After about 10-minutes add the reserved asparagus trimmings.
8. Keep adding stock as needed so there is always a 1/2cm liquid layer over the rice.
9. After 15 to 20 minutes, the rice should be close to al dente.
10. At this stage add the reserved pancetta, asparagus and asparagus puree and cold butter and the finely grated cheese.
11. Taste and adjust seasoning
12. Now cover the pan, and allow it to stand for 2-3 minutes.

To Prepare the stock and asparagus:

1. Bring your vegetable stock to the boil then blanch the asparagus spears briefly in it. Remove and set aside.
2. Trim the bottom 1cm from the asparagus and set aside to use half way through the cooking of the risotto
3. Now cut the remaining asparagus in half, the tips will be added at the very end of cooking the risotto.
4. To make the asparagus puree, blend the middle third of the asparagus spears with a few tablespoons of stock in a small processor until completely smooth, reserve.

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Spaghetti alla Puttanesca

Spaghetti in the style of "whores"

Serves 6

Ingredients

450g dried spaghetti

1/2 cup (120ml) extra-virgin olive oil, divided

4 medium cloves garlic, thinly sliced or finely chopped by hand (see note above)

4 to 6 anchovy fillets, finely chopped (20–30ml chopped anchovy)

Large pinch red pepper flakes

1/4 cup capers, drained and chopped (60g)

1/4 cup chopped pitted black olives (60g)

1 (14-ounce; about 400g) can whole peeled tomatoes, preferably San Marzano, roughly broken up by hand

Small handful minced fresh parsley leaves

1 ounce (30g) finely grated Pecorino Romano or Parmesan cheese, plus more for serving

Freshly ground black pepper

Method

1. In a medium skillet, combine 6 tablespoons oil, garlic, anchovies, and red pepper flakes. Cook over medium heat until garlic is very lightly golden, about 5 minutes. (Adjust heat as necessary to keep it gently sizzling.) Add capers and olives and stir to combine.
2. Add chopped and deseeded tomatoes, stir to combine, and bring to a bare simmer. Continue to simmer until tomatoes have started to break down and flavours have balanced nicely.
3. Now cook your spaghetti to just under al dente (about 1 minute less than the package recommends).
4. Using tongs, transfer pasta to sauce. Alternatively, drain pasta through a colander, reserving 1 cup of the cooking water. Add drained pasta to sauce.
5. Add a few tablespoons of pasta water to sauce and increase heat to bring pasta and sauce to a vigorous simmer. Cook, stirring and shaking the pan and adding more pasta water as necessary to keep sauce loose, until pasta is perfectly al dente, 1 to 2 minutes longer. (The pasta will cook more slowly in the sauce than it did in the water.) Stir in remaining olive oil, parsley, and cheese.
6. Season with salt and pepper. (Be generous with the pepper and scant with the salt—the dish will be plenty salty from the other ingredients.) If using, stir in canned tuna and break it up with a fork. Serve immediately with more grated cheese at the table.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

The Colony Shopping Centre, 345 Jan Smuts Avenue, Craighall, 2024.

www.facebook.com/secretjozichef

GREEN BEAN ALMOND AND FETA SALAD

INGREDIENTS

⅓ cup sliced almonds
450gms green beans, trimmed and cut into
7cm long pieces
¼ cup water
½ teaspoon fine sea salt, divided 2
tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
1 tablespoon lemon juice (about ½ lemon)
2 teaspoons Dijon mustard
1 small-to-medium clove garlic
1/4tsp freshly ground black pepper
Pinch of red pepper flakes
¼ cup crumbled feta cheese, divided
3 to 4 large basil leaves, torn or chopped,
for garnish
Lemon zest from about ½ lemon, for garnish

INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Start with a large skillet over medium heat. Add the almonds and cook, stirring frequently (careful, they burn quickly). After 3 minutes, reduce the heat to medium-low, and continue stirring until they are fragrant and turning golden on the edges, about 1 to 3 more minutes. Transfer the almonds to a bowl to cool.

Step 2: Make sure the heat is set to medium-low and place the skillet back on the heat. Immediately add the green beans, water and ¼ teaspoon salt. Cover and cook, stirring occasionally, until the beans are nearly tender, about 7 to 10 minutes. Remove the lid, raise heat to medium-high, and cook until the liquid evaporates, 2 to 5 minutes. Remove the skillet from the heat and set aside.

Step 3: Meanwhile, whisk together the olive oil, lemon juice, mustard, garlic, black pepper, red pepper flakes and remaining ¼ teaspoon salt. Set aside.

Step 4: Once the green beans are done cooking, whisk the olive oil mixture once more, then pour it into the skillet. Pour the almonds back into the skillet, and add about half of the feta, reserving the other half for garnish. Toss to combine, then taste and add more lemon juice or black pepper if necessary.

Step 5: Transfer the green beans to a serving bowl or platter. Sprinkle the remaining feta and the torn basil leaves on top. Lightly grate some lemon zest on top, and serve promptly.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

AMALFI STYLE LEMON CHICKEN

INGREDIENTS

6 chicken fillets
1/2 cup all purpose flour for coating
1 tsp salt
1/2 tsp freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp Lemon olive oil
2 cloves, finely chopped
Zest of 1 lemon
2 tbsp olive oil
1tsp finely chopped rosemary
1/2 cup white wine (or chicken stock)
1/4 cup white balsamic
1/4 cup lemon juice
1/4 cup water
Butter (optional)

METHOD

1. Pat dry fillets with a paper towel, butterfly them, and with a meat mallet gently flatten to an even thickness. In a shallow dish, combine the flour, salt, and black pepper. Lightly dredge each chicken thigh in the flour mixture, shaking off any excess for a thin coating.

2. Heat oil, rosemary, garlic in a large non-stick skillet on medium-high. Place fillet and sear 1 to 2 minutes on each side until lightly golden brown. Remove chicken and set aside. Deglaze pan with wine or chicken stock.

3. Add balsamic, lemon juice and lemon zest. Gently simmer for two minutes. Reduce heat to low, cover pan and cook for 5 minutes then add the chicken and cook a further 5 minutes until chicken is cooked through, occasionally basting. Swirl in 2 tablespoons of Butter olive oil for rich and glossy finish. Serve with spoonfuls of sauce and a drizzle of olive oil.

THE
COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef

CROSTINI WITH HERBED RICOTTA & ANCHOVY SALSA OIL

INGREDIENTS

1 baguette

Olive oil for drizzling

For the herbed ricotta

400g fresh ricotta

1 small clove garlic

Grated zest and juice 1 lemon

50ml olive oil

For the anchovy salsa

Handful fresh flatleaf parsley

50g good quality anchovy fillets in
olive oil, drained

2 tbsp capers, drained

½ garlic clove, finely grated

Grated zest and juice 1 lemon

2-3 tbsp extra-virgin olive oil

METHOD

Step 1: Heat the oven to 160°C. Cut the baguette diagonally into thin slices and arrange on a baking sheet. Drizzle with olive oil and bake for 10-12 minutes until crisp. Set aside to cool.

Step 2: Put the ricotta, garlic, lemon zest and half the juice in a food processor. Pulse briefly while drizzling in the 50ml olive oil to give a chunky purée. Add salt and pepper, along with more lemon juice if needed

Step 3: For the salsa: place the parsley, anchovies and capers, garlic, lemon zest and juice in the bowl of a food processor. Add the olive oil to cover. And run until the mixture is a smooth green oil. Season with salt, pepper and more lemon juice if needed.

Step 4: Dollop the ricotta purée onto the crostini and drizzle generously with anchovy salsa oil to serve.

THE COOKERY

by The Secret Jozi Chef